Foreword

I am delighted to be writing this foreword for one of India's brightest and rising young economic scholars, Professor Chinmay Tumbe of the Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad. *India Moving* is terrific in many ways. It is the kind of book that I would want to write and read, and dip into and refer to from time to time. But those are not the only reasons for me writing this foreword. Nor are my motives sullied by the obligation of reciprocity: Chinmay, who I got to know serendipitously, contributed wonderfully to a chapter in the *Economic Survey of 2016–17*. The reasons for my enthusiasm are different.

There is a certain kind of scholarship that young Indian academics, especially in economics, have shied away from. A major reason is the suffocating straitjacket of the discipline as it is currently practised in prestigious universities of the United States. Increasingly, the rewards are confined to, and conferred upon those, practising a certain narrow conception of scholarship. This privileges the asking and answering of small questions because only these can be answered through methods that the high priests of the Academy certify as rigorously kosher. As a consequence, Dismal Science risks becoming Small, Lesser, Wannabe Science.

Against this background, it takes a certain confidence—chutzpah even—to escape the choke of a throttling Academy, especially for someone as professionally young as Chinmay Tumbe, and for someone who practises his vocation in India, far away from the academic centres of gravity. But make no mistake, *India Moving*: *A History of Migration* is a Big Book, taking on nothing less than the history of national and international migration from, to and within India over the last several centuries. Just the